

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

Charitable Interpretation

In the first week of April, Theo did something Theo had been doing for a long time, only this time he had a name for it.

The thing Theo did was choose the charitable interpretation of a moment in the hallway between fourth and fifth period.

Here is what happened.

Theo was at his locker. A boy named Cole, who is in Theo's grade but not in the cohort, walked past Theo on his way to fifth period. As Cole walked past, Cole said — in a voice that could have meant anything — *Theo. Looking good today, buddy.*

The sentence had not been delivered in a kind tone, exactly. It had also not been delivered in an unkind tone, exactly. It had been delivered in the kind of flat affect that twelve-year-old boys sometimes use, the kind of voice where the meaning is — and this is genuinely true — not determinable from the audio alone.

Theo had two interpretations available to him in real time.

Interpretation A. Cole was being friendly. Cole had noticed Theo's new haircut, which Theo had gotten on Saturday, and which had been, by Theo's own assessment, a slightly more daring haircut than his usual. Cole was complimenting it. The *buddy* at the end was just Cole-being-Cole.

Interpretation B. Cole was being sarcastic. Cole had noticed Theo's new haircut and was mocking it. *Looking good* was

sarcasm. *Buddy* was condescension. The whole sentence was a small dig that Theo was supposed to feel without being able to formally object to.

Both interpretations were possible. Both were consistent with the audio. Theo could not, in real time, with the available evidence, distinguish between them.

Theo, having spent seventh grade getting better at noticing his own internal moves, did a thing he could not have done a year ago. He noticed himself reaching for Interpretation B.

The reaching for Interpretation B was — and Theo could feel this — the script working. The script in Theo's head — *I am the one who watches, I am not the protagonist* — predicted that anybody talking to him in a flat tone was probably making fun of him. The script had a long history of being right just often enough that the script had trained itself, over years, to assume B.

Theo, in the hallway, mid-step, paused.

He said in his head, *I am reaching for B. I do not, actually, have evidence for B. I have a flat-affect sentence from Cole, with two possible interpretations, and I am picking the worse one because my script tells me to.*

He thought, for a half-second, *what would A look like.*

A would look like: *thanks Cole. The haircut is new. I have been a little nervous about it.*

He said it.

He said, *thanks Cole. The haircut is new. I have been a little nervous about it.*

Cole stopped walking. Cole turned around.

Cole said — and the tone had now updated, because Cole had received information from Theo's response — Cole said, *Theo, it looks good. I mean it. My mom got me a haircut on*

Saturday too and I have been hiding from it. Yours actually works.

Theo said, *oh. Thanks.*

Cole said, *all right. Fifth period.*

Cole walked away.

Theo stood at his locker for one extra second.

He thought, I almost went into fifth period believing Cole was making fun of me. The whole rest of my day would have been a slightly worse day. The interpretation cost me nothing to switch. The switch changed the entire shape of the next six hours.

This is the lesson of Chapter Eighteen.



There is a phrase we are going to give you for this. The phrase is **charitable interpretation**.

Charitable interpretation is the practice of, when a piece of evidence is ambiguous — when somebody's tone could be neutral or could be hostile, when somebody's text could be friendly or could be cool, when somebody's facial expression could be tired or could be disappointed in you — picking the kindest available interpretation that is consistent with the evidence.

You do not pick the most flattering interpretation. You do not pick the most delusional one. You pick the kindest one that is consistent with the data.

In Cole's case, the data was: a flat-affect sentence saying *Theo, looking good today, buddy*. The kindest interpretation consistent with the data was *Cole noticed the haircut and was complimenting it*. That was a perfectly reasonable interpretation. The hostile interpretation — *Cole was being sarcastic* — was also consistent with the data, but it was no

more supported than the kind one. Both interpretations had the same evidence behind them. Theo could have picked either.

The script told Theo to pick the hostile one. The script was using the data selectively. The script was applying a heavier weight to *consistent with hostility* than to *consistent with kindness*, because the script's job was to keep Theo defended.

Charitable interpretation is the practice of noticing the script and overriding it on purpose when the evidence allows.

This is not about being naive. This is not about always assuming the best of everybody. People do, in fact, sometimes mean the hostile thing. People do, in fact, sometimes make fun of you. The data sometimes clearly supports the hostile interpretation, and in those cases, you do not have to pretend it does not. Charitable interpretation is not denial. Charitable interpretation is what you do when the evidence is genuinely ambiguous.

Most middle-school interactions are genuinely ambiguous. A tone could be anything. A look could be anything. A text could be anything. The evidence, most of the time, is not enough to determine intent. When the evidence is not enough, you have to pick. You always have to pick. Your nervous system will pick for you, automatically, based on your scripts, if you do not make the picking conscious.

Charitable interpretation is the practice of making the picking conscious, and picking the kinder one when the evidence allows.



A note about the cost-benefit.

The cost of charitable interpretation, when you are wrong, is low. If Cole had, in fact, been being sarcastic, and Theo had

responded to Interpretation A — *thanks Cole, the haircut is new, I have been nervous about it* — the worst-case scenario is that Cole would have not updated, would have continued his sarcastic tone, and Theo would have realized within ten seconds that the interpretation had been wrong. Then Theo could update. The update is fast and easy. The cost of having tried A first is, in real terms, ten seconds of social awkwardness.

The cost of uncharitable interpretation, when you are wrong, is high. If Theo had picked B and Cole had actually been being kind, then Theo would have responded coldly or defensively, and Cole would have walked away thinking *Theo is moody*, and the friendship — or the potential friendship — would have suffered, and Theo would have spent the rest of the day in a slightly worse mood, and the whole interaction would have been net-negative.

The asymmetry is real. The cost of being wrong in the charitable direction is small. The cost of being wrong in the uncharitable direction is large.

Mathematicians would tell you: when the costs are asymmetric, you should bias toward the side with the lower cost of being wrong. The math says: pick charitable. When in doubt. As a default. Because the cost of being wrong is much smaller.

This is also, in some real way, the underlying logic of grace. Grace is the practice of extending something generous to somebody who has not earned it. Grace is, in some real way, the behavioral version of charitable interpretation. When the data is ambiguous, when the evidence is not enough, when the person has done a thing that might have been hostile or might have been clumsy — grace says: *assume clumsy. Behave as if the clumsy interpretation is true. See what happens.* You will,

sometimes, be wrong. The person, sometimes, will have meant the hostile thing. You will, in those cases, find out within a short time, and you can update.

But most of the time, the kind interpretation is correct, or close enough to correct that the difference does not matter. And the consistent practice of picking kindness, in a life full of these ambiguous interactions, has effects that compound. You build, around yourself, a field of small kindnesses extended to ambiguous people. The field changes the people. The people who, in your presence, are treated as if they meant the kind thing — those people, surprisingly often, become the kind version of themselves. Not always. Not for the genuinely cruel. But for the large middle of humanity, which is mostly clumsy and tired and self-absorbed and not really thinking about you — for that middle, your charitable interpretations are a small daily kindness that the world is, in some real way, better with than without.

This is — and we are going to say it loudly — not about being a doormat. We are going to spend the next chapter on the difference. Charitable interpretation does not require you to absorb harm. It does not require you to extend grace to people who are actively hurting you. It is a default for ambiguous data, not a rule for clearly hostile data. But the default matters. The default is what your nervous system does, every day, hundreds of times, in interactions where you have not consciously chosen. The default, if you do not work on it, will be whatever your scripts have written for you.

Most people's scripts default uncharitable. Most people, when in doubt, assume the hostile interpretation, because their scripts are protecting them from past harms.

The work of seventh grade, and eighth, and high school, and adulthood, is to adjust the default. To get your nervous

system, slowly, over many small daily practices, to bias toward charitable when the evidence is genuinely ambiguous.

Theo, in the hallway in April, made one small adjustment. The adjustment cost him nothing. The adjustment changed the rest of his day.

That is the practice. One small interaction at a time. Conscious. Deliberate. Until the default updates.

Try it tomorrow. With one person. Where the evidence is ambiguous. Pick the kinder interpretation. See what happens.

You can do this. You are old enough.

— J.A.R.